

Quokka Island: The World's Happiest Animal

Name: _____

Date: _____

Year 3 English — Reading

ACARA v9.0: AC9E3LY05

Learning Intention

I am learning to answer literal and inferential questions about an informative text.

Success Criteria

- I can find facts stated directly in the text.
- I can answer questions using clues from the text.
- I can explain my answer using evidence.

Quokka Island: The World's Happiest Animal

Off the coast of Western Australia sits a small island called Rottnest Island. It is famous for one very special animal: the quokka.

Quokkas are small marsupials, about the size of a domestic cat. They have round faces, big dark eyes and a wide mouth that curls upward — which is exactly why people call them "the happiest animal in the world." Their mouth shape isn't really a smile at all, but it certainly looks like one in photos!

Quokkas are marsupials, which means baby quokkas (called joeys) grow inside their mother's pouch, just like kangaroos and koalas. Adult quokkas mostly eat leaves, stems and bark from native plants, and they are most active at night.

Rottnest Island has almost no natural predators for quokkas, which is one reason so many quokkas live there safely. On mainland Australia, quokkas are far more vulnerable to foxes and cats, and their numbers have dropped a lot over the years. Today, quokkas are listed as a vulnerable species, and rangers on Rottnest Island work hard to protect their habitat.

Visitors love taking photos with quokkas, but rangers remind everyone that feeding or touching wild quokkas can actually harm them. The safest way to enjoy a quokka's famous smile is from a respectful distance.

Part A — Comprehension Questions

Q1. Where do quokkas famously live? _____

Q2. What are baby quokkas called? _____

Q3. True or False: Quokkas are reptiles. _____

Q4. What do adult quokkas mostly eat?

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Part B — More Comprehension Questions

Q5. Why is Rottnest Island a safer place for quokkas than the mainland?

Q6. What does 'vulnerable species' mean, based on the text?

Q7. Why do rangers ask visitors not to touch or feed quokkas?

Part C — Challenge: Think Deeper

A tourist visiting Rottnest Island wants to pick up a quokka to get a closer photo.

Q8. Using evidence from the text, explain why this is not a good idea.

Q9. The text says a quokka's mouth shape 'isn't really a smile at all.' Explain what this tells you about how the text wants readers to think about the quokka's famous nickname.

Q10. Suggest one reason why protecting quokkas on Rottnest Island might also help protect quokkas everywhere in Australia.

Answer Key — Part A & B

A1: Rottnest Island, off the coast of Western Australia.

A2: Joeys.

A3: False — quokkas are marsupials (mammals), not reptiles.

A4: Leaves, stems and bark from native plants.

A5: Rottnest Island has almost no natural predators for quokkas.

A6: It means a species is at risk of becoming endangered or declining in number.

A7: Because feeding or touching wild quokkas can actually harm them.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: The text explains that touching wild quokkas can harm them, so picking one up could hurt the animal even if the tourist doesn't mean to.

C9: It tells readers that the 'happy' look is just the natural shape of the quokka's mouth, not a real expression of emotion — encouraging readers to see the animal accurately rather than just as a cute photo trend.

C10: Any reasonable answer (e.g. successful conservation methods used on Rottnest Island, like predator control, could be studied and applied to protect quokka populations on the mainland too) — teacher to check.